

UPSC Philosophy Optional Paper 1 Simulation

QUESTION PAPER | Time: 3 Hours | Maximum Marks: 250

INSTRUCTIONS

1. The paper has two sections, A and B, and eight questions.
2. Question 1 and Question 5 are compulsory.
3. Answer three other questions, choosing at least one from each section.
4. Answer five questions in all. The marks carried by each subpart are indicated.

SECTION A - Western Philosophy

Q1 (COMPULSORY)

- (a) "Aristotle rejects the separation of the Forms, not form itself." Examine this claim. [10 marks]
- (b) "History is a process of dialectical change." In the light of this statement discuss Hegel's approach in understanding history. [10 marks]
- (c) "The epoche brackets the world." Examine the accuracy of this formulation. [10 marks]
- (d) "That thing is said to be free which exists solely from the necessity of its own nature, and is determined to action by itself alone." Discuss Spinoza's views on freedom and determinism in the light of the above statement. [10 marks]
- (e) Distinguish between senseless (sinnlos) and nonsensical (unsinnig) propositions in the Tractatus, and explain why the distinction matters. Discuss. [10 marks]

Q2

- (a) "Plato's theory of Forms fails not from external attack but from the internal incompatibility of two demands it places on Forms." Critically evaluate. [20 marks]
- (b) "Aristotle's final cause asserts directedness, not design." Discuss with suitable examples, and assess whether teleology survives the objection that it is unscientific. [15 marks]
- (c) "Hegel's dialectic is defensible as a description of conceptual breakdown and indefensible as a claim to necessity." Examine this statement. [15 marks]

Q3

- (a) "The transition from the Logic to the Philosophy of Nature is the point at which Hegel's system either completes itself or shows its seam." Critically examine. [20 marks]
- (b) Assess Husserl's claim that free imaginative variation yields knowledge of essences rather than empirical generalisations. [15 marks]
- (c) "From the necessity of the divine nature there must follow infinitely many things in infinitely many ways." Explain this statement by Spinoza along with some possible criticisms. [15 marks]

Q4

- (a) "Husserl's transcendental phenomenology escapes psychologism only by relocating it." Critically examine. [20 marks]
- (b) "Moore's method protects ordinary knowledge at the cost of leaving philosophy without a criterion." Examine this statement. [15 marks]
- (c) "I can always choose, but I ought to know that if I do not choose, I am still choosing". Critically discuss Sartre's conception of choice and responsibility in the light of above statement. [15 marks]

SECTION B - Indian Philosophy

Q5 (COMPULSORY)

- (a) Are the Carvakas consistent when they hold that inference is not a source of knowledge? Discuss. [10 marks]
- (b) "If Purusa and Prakrti are two completely independent realities, then no relation between the two is possible." In the light of this statement make a brief presentation of Sankara's criticism of Samkhya dualism. [10 marks]
- (c) Explain the nature and role of Supermind in evolution as per Aurobindo's philosophy. [10 marks]
- (d) Does the seed contain the tree? Discuss with reference to Nyaya-Vaisesika Philosophy. [10 marks]
- (e) Discuss the nature and types of matter according to Nimbarka. [10 marks]

Q6

- (a) Differentiate between the Carvakas' refutation of self as a transcendental category and the Buddhist rejection of atma. [20 marks]
- (b) Critically evaluate Carvakas' rejection of Akasa as one of the elements of reality and examine their criticism of transmigration of Soul. [15 marks]
- (c) Explain the Samkhya view on three gunas (guna-traya) and their modifications. [15 marks]

Q7

- (a) "A mango tree is grown out of a mango seed." How will Samkhya system explain this process through their theory of causation by rejecting their rival perspectives? [20 marks]
- (b) "Our Yoga is a double movement of ascent and descent." Discuss the above statement in the context of Sri Aurobindo's conception of Integral Yoga. [15 marks]
- (c) Elucidate Naiyayikas view of ordinary and extraordinary perception. Are they justified in accepting that universals are perceived? Discuss. [15 marks]

Q8

- (a) According to Sri Aurobindo, 'the awakening of the psychic being and its gradual prominence over all other parts of the being is the first step in the conscious evolution of man'. Explain and examine. [20 marks]
- (b) Discuss the nature and relationship of Jiva and Jiva-saksi according to non-dualism. [15 marks]
- (c) Explain Buddhist concept of Triratna and their internal relation. Critically examine the consistency of Triratnas with the Buddhist concept of No-soul (Nairatmyavada). [15 marks]

END OF PAPER